

Category Turbulence

Aging as Nullifying Process of Social Category

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Abstract

How does age category intersect with other social categories, such as gender, race and ethnicity? Conventional studies conceptualize age as life course (???), but categorical view on age is less developed. In this article, I argue that age acts as *category turbulence*, categorical characteristic that nullifies other category's ex-ante conditions, such as gender role and orderly bodies. I conclude incorporating people with old-age with a categorical perspective advances sociological debates on social categories and their intersectionality.

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A replication package is available at github.com/sittaningo/replication/tree/main/XXX. When the paper is accepted, the replication package in gitub will be archived on Dataverse. [about data]. [appreciate feedbacks].

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Conflict of Interest

None declared.

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Introduction

One of the most well-documented concepts in sociology is social category. Social category, such as gender, race and ethnicity, divides and stratifies human beings, finally generating social inequality in a broader realm of society: labor market (Goldin 2014), family (McLanahan 2004) and health (Case and Deaton 2015). Recently, scholars have paid more attention to intersectionality, which emphasizes on consolidation of social categories (Collins 2015).

- TODO: McLanahan SPEAKS TO RACE?

Going beyond examining categorical and intersectional inequality, a growing studies have begun to argue *how* social categories consolidate and shape hidden dimension of social inequality. For example, Weisshaar et al. (2024) coined the term “diversity values” in discrimination in hiring, that personnels value females as well as Black as the exchangeable and quantifiable social categories. Monk et al. (2021) found substantial heterogeneity among gender and racial disparity in wage by quantifying “bodily capital.” As such, it advances sociological understandings of social categories to theorize a given social category can be actually conceptualize.

Contrary to the proliferation of gender and racial categories, age has hitherto existed as a haunting vacuum in studies of social categories. Age as social category has long-lasting attention in sociology (Parsons 1942; Linton 1942; Neugarten et al. 1965; Riley et al. 1972; Jr. and Mayer 1997; Barrett 2022). But age is now collapsed into life course approach. As Barrett (2022, 218) argues, “the most common approach was to examine some given process occurring over the life course, with scant attention to other dimensions of age, including age discrimination, ageism, or age identity.” Barrett (2022) foreshadows sociology of age and reconceptualizes age category as institution, performance and identity. However, Barrett (2022) does not consider how age category intersects with gender and race.

In this article, I argue that old-age functions as *category turbulence* to other social categories such as gender and race. Category turbulence is defined as a categorical characteristic that nullifies other category’s ex-ante conditions, such as gender role (?) and orderly bodies [Peters.2025e3d]. Concretely, category turbulence occurs through two pathways: *positional* turbulence and *bodily* turbulence. *Positional* turbulence disrupts social expectations surrounding a social category. Men serves higher human capital than women because of division of labor (Becker 1991).

Women have higher risks for paid leave for their familial obligation (?). Old-age men and women may be viewed as homogeneous due to ageism (?) and compositional change in human capital (Autor and Dorn 2009; Sullivan 2010). *Bodily* turbulence disrupts expectation of orderly bodies. For example, racial difference in skin tone may be in turmoil by wrinkle and stooped posture. In old age, social inequality in gender and race is no longer confirmed by category turbulence.

To address category turbulence, I carry out the survey experiment in hiring.

Results show...

These results can support alternative conceptualization of age: *category turbulence*. To unlock the concept category turbulence goes beyond conceptualization of aging as cumulative process across the life course (DiPrete and Eirich 2006). Rather, aging can be viewed as discrete transition (Riley et al. 1972), especially regarding transition from working-age (or prime-age) to old-age. Such discrete transition disavows *cues* of social category (Monk 2022) through positional turbulence and bodily turbulence. <SEEMS TOO MUCH!>

Aging as Continuous and Discrete Transition

In “A Sociology of Age Stratification,” Riley et al. (1972) build age stratification theory, which organized elements of age structure and their generating process. Specifically,

Data and Methods

Results

Discussion

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